AI Student Innovation Hackathon - Full Program

Finalized mechanics for non-IT college junior participants

1. Program Overview

The AI Student Innovation Hackathon is a beginner-friendly program for non-IT college junior students. It combines design thinking, responsible generative AI use, AI-assisted building, and structured project presentation. The challenge is released during the first session so teams can plan early, and actual prototype building begins in the second session.

Teams work within a fixed 2,000-token allocation on the approved AI build platform. The token cap is intentionally part of the learning design: students must scope a realistic solution, write purposeful prompts, test carefully, and finish within limited AI resources.

Program Component	Schedule	Primary Purpose
Session 1	October 6, 2026 | 7:00-8:30 PM	Design Thinking + AI Basics; release challenge; select problem; begin solution planning
Session 2	October 7 | 7:00-8:30 PM	Platform walkthrough, prompt engineering, sample builds; teams begin actual prototype
Session 3	October 8 | 7:00-8:30 PM	Build consultation, testing, troubleshooting, scope control, pitch preparation
Submission	October 14, 2026	Final prototype and required evidence submitted; project is frozen
Final Showcase & Judging	October 16, 2026 | Whole day	Presentation, live demonstration, Q&A, judging, deliberation, awarding

2. Participants and Team Structure

- Target participants: non-IT college junior students.
- Three (3) students per team.
- Beginners are welcome; prior programming experience is not required.
- Each team should distribute responsibilities across problem/user understanding, AI building/prompting, and testing/presentation. Roles may overlap, but all three members must understand the full project.
- School faculty/coaches and Hexcore Labs trainers may guide, ask questions, and troubleshoot platform issues, but may not build the team's final solution.

3. Program Objectives

1. Identify and define a specific student problem before proposing a solution.
2. Understand the intended user and the context in which the problem occurs.
3. Use design thinking to select a realistic, focused solution.
4. Understand basic generative AI concepts, limitations, and responsible use.
5. Use the approved AI build platform and prompt engineering to create a functional prototype.
6. Manage a limited allocated-token project budget effectively.
7. Test the main user journey and improve the prototype based on observed issues.
8. Explain the build process, AI contribution, limitations, and student decisions.
9. Present and defend the completed solution before judges.

4. Official Challenges

Challenge	Scenario / Design Question	Guardrails
Bullying / Peer Pressure	Students may experience bullying, exclusion, peer pressure, or uncomfortable situations but may not know what to do, how to respond safely, or where to seek help. How might AI and digital technology help students better understand situations and access appropriate support?	Do not identify or accuse real individuals; do not determine guilt; do not encourage retaliation; do not collect real reports for judging; do not replace official school reporting, counseling, or investigation.
Time Management / Academic Load	Students often balance classes, assignments, exams, group work, organizations, work, commuting, and personal responsibilities. How might AI and digital technology help students plan, prioritize, and use their time more effectively?	Do not complete graded work for users; do not encourage academic dishonesty; do not diagnose stress/burnout; do not guarantee grades or outcomes; the user must remain in control of priorities and decisions.

5. Session Plan

Session 1 - Design Thinking + AI Basics

The official challenge is released in Session 1. Teams may begin planning immediately after the briefing; no need to wait until the hackathon day.

Block	Topics / Activity	Expected Team Evidence
Orientation	Program mechanics, token limit, submission deadline, judging philosophy	Team understands rules and resource constraints
Design Thinking	Target user, problem framing, root causes, “How Might We” question, solution ideation	Chosen challenge, target user, specific problem, one focused solution concept
AI Basics	Generative AI, hallucinations, bias, privacy, human review, purposeful prompting	Initial AI use plan and risks/guardrails
Planning Start	Define primary user journey, must-have function, token budget plan	Draft build plan before Session 2

Session 2 - Platform Walkthrough + Prompt Engineering + Build Start

Block	Topics / Activity	Expected Team Evidence
Platform Walkthrough	Workspace navigation, project creation, token visibility, saving versions	Team can independently navigate the approved platform
Prompt Engineering	Context, user, task, requirements, constraints, test conditions	First structured build prompt
Sample Programs	Neutral sample builds unrelated to official challenge solutions	Students understand how prompts translate to a working prototype
Build Start	Teams use their own challenge plan and begin the actual prototype	Working first version or functional core flow

Session 3 - Build Consultation + Testing + Pitch Preparation

Block	Focus	Expected Team Evidence
Consultation	Scope control, prompt refinement, troubleshooting, removing unnecessary features	Clear priority list and remaining token plan
Testing	Normal input, incomplete input, unexpected input, challenge-specific safety test	Test log and corrections
Finalization	Complete main user journey, warnings/guardrails, usability improvements	Submission-ready prototype
Pitch Preparation	Problem, user, solution, live demo, process, token strategy, lessons learned	Short final pitch and Q&A readiness

6. Token-Based Build Rules

- Each team receives a maximum project allocation of subscription tokens on the approved build platform.
- The token cap applies to the team project, not per student.
- Teams may start using tokens once building officially begins in Session 2.
- Tokens should be treated as a project resource. Teams are expected to plan before prompting, build the minimum viable solution first, test in small steps, and avoid repeatedly regenerating the entire project.
- Unused tokens do not automatically earn a higher score. Judges assess whether the team used its limited resources deliberately and still completed the solution.
- A team that exhausts its token allocation and does not produce a functional submission by the deadline is marked INCOMPLETE and is not eligible to place.
- Teams must submit their final token usage or platform usage record together with the project.

Fairness rule: resource management is judged together with completion. A team that responsibly uses 1,950 tokens to finish a strong prototype can outscore a team that uses only 900 tokens but produces a weak solution.

7. Project Requirements

- A clearly identified target user and specific problem.
- One primary user journey that works from beginning to end.
- At least one meaningful interactive function.
- A prototype substantially created during the official program using the approved platform.
- At least three documented tests and corrections.
- Appropriate challenge-specific guardrails and a simple limitations statement.
- A brief build/process log showing major prompts, decisions, changes, and token use.
- A project that all three students can explain and demonstrate.

Possible internal reference outputs include an interactive guide, planning tool, assistant, decision support tool, quiz, dashboard, or another functional digital prototype. These examples should not be used to pre-empt student ideation.

8. Submission and Project Freeze

Requirement	Rule
Deadline	October 14, 2026, two days before the final event.
Required submission	Prototype link/file, team summary, student workbook/evidence, final token usage, test results, and presentation file or outline.
Project freeze	No new features or material changes after submission. Only organizer-approved fixes for access/link failure are permitted.
Final event	October 18 is for presentation, live demonstration, Q&A, judging, deliberation, and awarding - not for continued building.

9. Fair Judging Framework

All output formats are judged using the same criteria. Judges should not reward complexity, number of features, visual polish, or token consumption by itself. The central question is whether the students understood a real problem, built an appropriate working solution, managed their AI resources, tested it, and can explain what they created.

Criterion	Weight	What Judges Look For
Problem Understanding & Solution Design	35	Clear understanding of the problem, target user, root need, and how the proposed system addresses it. Judges look for thoughtful decisions, appropriate features, and a well-designed solution.
System & Functionality	35	How well the AI system works from the user's perspective. The main workflow should function, features should serve a purpose, and the solution should be complete and usable.
Student Ownership & Build Process	20	Students can explain how they created the system, including their prompts, decisions, testing, corrections, AI behavior, limitations, and individual contributions.
Presentation & Demonstration	10	Clear and organized explanation of the problem and solution, effective live demonstration, and ability to answer judges' questions confidently and accurately.

Automatic incomplete condition: if the team consumes the full token allocation and has no functional submitted output by October 14, the project cannot be placed.

10. Presentation and Judging Day

Component	Recommended Format
Team Presentation	5-7 minutes: problem, target user, solution, development process, token strategy
Live Demonstration	3-5 minutes: complete primary user journey
Judge Q&A	5 minutes: ownership, system understanding, testing, guardrails, token decisions
Exhibit / Review Window	Optional whole-day rotation for judges, schools, sponsors, and guests
Deliberation & Awards	Scores consolidated; ties resolved using ownership, problem understanding, functionality, then token/process score

11. Coach and Trainer Boundaries

May Support	May Not Do
Clarify instructions; ask guiding questions; explain platform functions; troubleshoot access; suggest testing methods; help teams manage time and scope.	Choose the final idea; write the team's full prompts; build major functions; use tokens on behalf of the students; prepare the final pitch; answer judges for the team.

12. Definition of Success

- Teams finish a functional prototype within the fixed AI resource limit.
- Students can explain the problem, the user, the system, and the process used to build it.
- Students demonstrate intentional rather than wasteful use of generative AI.
- Projects address Bullying/Peer Pressure or Time Management with appropriate guardrails.
- Students gain practical confidence in turning an idea into a working digital solution even without an IT background.